

Session 17: Reconciliation of the Brothers

Key Takeaways

- Returning to the flood melody, Yoseph's offer of refuge in Egypt echoes the safety of the ark during the de-creation of the cosmos.
- The name Goshen is a wordplay on the Hebrew word for "garden" (gan), representing an abundance of God's provision in the midst of famine.
- God rescuing Yaaqov's family from destruction is about a rebirth for all humanity.
- Yehudah's self-sacrifice reverses the pattern of sibling rivalry and conflict that runs through the entire book of Genesis.

Section 3: Genesis 45:1-25a

A – Genesis 45:1-3

Yoseph Reveals Himself to His Brothers

- **45:2** "and he gave his voice in **weeping (בכי)** "
- **45:2** "**and Egypt heard, and it was heard in the house of Pharaoh** "
- **45:3** "and he said, 'I am Yoseph, your brother!'"
- **45:3** "and they could not answer him, because **they were stunned (בהל)** "

B – Genesis 45:4-13

45:4-7

- **45:4** "I am Yoseph your brother!"
- **45:7** "**Elohim sent me** here before you, to keep alive a remnant for you"
- **45:6** "**there are still five more years of the famine** "

45:8

- "Pharaoh has placed me as a father ... and a master ... and a ruler over all the land"

45:9-13

- **45:9** "**Elohim has placed me** as a master for all of Egypt"

- 45:11 “there are still five more years of the famine”

A' – 45:14-25a

Yoseph and the Brothers Embrace

- 45:14-15 “and he wept (בכה), and he kissed his brothers, and wept (בכה) over them”
- 45:16 “And the voice was heard in the house of Pharaoh”
- 45:24 “And he sent his brothers ... and said to them, ‘Don’t disturb each other (רגז) on the road!’”

Genesis 45:1-25. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

In this section, Yoseph reveals himself to his brothers while also revealing his understanding of God’s plan in all of these terrible events. Yoseph becomes an interpreter not just of dreams, but of his own life story. He sees the providence of God turning the brothers’ evil into good.

Notice the symmetrical design of this section.

- In the outer parts (Gen. 45:1-3 and 45:14-25a), Yoseph’s weeping is highlighted, as well as the loud sound of crying that can be heard all throughout the royal palace. These outer sections also show the brothers in a state of shock (נבהל, Gen. 45:3) and agitation (רגז, Gen. 45:24). These two words are often used as synonyms for people in a state of shock, fear, and anger when they experience traumatic events (see Exod. 15:14; Joel 2:1).
- In the center part (Gen. 45:4-13), Yoseph twice warns his brothers about the five remaining years of famine (these warnings form a literary frame around verse 8), and he tells them how Elohim turned the brother’s treachery into a rescue by sending him to Egypt to become ruler of all.

Yoseph Reveals Himself to His Brothers

¹ And Yoseph was not able to restrain himself for all those standing by him,
and he called out,
“Every man, go out from me!”
And no man stood with him when Yoseph made himself known to his brothers .

² And he gave his voice in weeping,
and Egypt heard,
and the house of Phar’oh heard,

³ and Yoseph said to his brothers ,
“I am Yoseph!
Is my father alive?!”
And his brothers were not able to answer him,

because they were stunned before him.

Genesis 45:1-3. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Yoseph's Speech of Self-Revealing

⁴ And Yoseph said to his brothers,
"Draw near to me, please!"

And they drew near.

And he said,

"I am Yoseph, **your brother** !

The one you sold to Egypt!

A ⁵ And now, don't let your heart be grieved with pain,
and don't let there be hot anger in your eyes,
because you sold me here,
because **Elohim sent me before you all for the preservation of life !**

B ⁶ Because these **two years of famine** have been in the midst of the land,
and there are **yet five years** in which there is no plowing or harvest,

⁷ and **Elohim sent me before you all**

A' to set up for you all **a remnant** in the land,
and **to preserve you all alive** ,
as **a great escaped-remnant**.

⁸ So now, **you all did not send me here, but Elohim** ,
and **he has set me up as a father to Phar'oh** ,
and **as a master for all his house** ,
and **as one who rules over all the land of Egypt** .

⁹ **Hurry**, and **go up** to **my father** ,
and say to him,

'Thus says Yoseph **your son** ,

"Elohim has set me up as master of all Egypt .

Come down to me.

Don't just stand there!

a ¹⁰ **And you will dwell in the land of Goshen** ,

b and you will be close to me,

c you and your sons and the sons of your sons,

and your flocks and your cattle and everything that is yours.

a' ¹¹ **And I will support you there** ,

b' because there are **five more years of famine** ,

c' so that you are not dispossessed, you and your house and everything that is yours."

¹² And look, your **eyes** are **seeing** ,

and the **eyes** of **my brother Binyamin**,
 that it is my **mouth** that is **speaking** to you.
 13 So you must tell **my father** of all my honor in Egypt,
 and of everything that you've **seen**,
 and **you must hurry** and **bring down my father** to here."

Genesis 45:4-13. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Yoseph as an Image of Elohim and a New Noah

When Yoseph reveals himself to his brothers, his speech is packed with verbal links back to the portraits of the image of God from Genesis 1:26-28 and to the story of Noah in Genesis 6-8.

Yoseph as the Image of Elohim

Humanity in Genesis 1-2	Yoseph in Genesis 45
Elohim created human as a divine image to rule (רדה, Gen. 1:26) over the land and its animals, as a mirror of the heavenly lights who were appointed to rule (משל, Gen. 1:14-16) over the day and night.	Elohim appointed Yoseph as a father and master of Egypt who will rule (משל, Gen. 45:8) over all the land of Egypt, and so the brothers are to tell their father to "go down" to Yoseph (רדה, ירד, Gen. 45:9) and to tell him of all the "honor/glory" (כבוד, Gen. 45:13).
Yahweh Elohim elevated human from the dust of the land outside of Eden and "gave him rest" (נוח, Gen. 2:15) in the garden to offer access to unending life (חי לעולם, Gen. 2:9; 3:22).	Elohim has elevated Yoseph from sale to slavery (Gen. 45:4) outside their homeland, up to a place of rule, in order to preserve life (למחיה, Gen. 45:5).
<i>Humanity in the Beginning and Joseph at the End. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Recall that Yoseph's dreams were about his future rule over his family and over "the sun, moon, and stars" (the only other time that phrase occurs in Genesis aside from Gen. 1:14-16). And so Yoseph is depicted as "ruling" (משל) with the same verb used of the rule of the heavenly lights in Genesis 1!

After the suffering of Yahweh's chosen one, they are elevated to a place of honor and rule over the nations, in order to provide life for all!

Yoseph as a New Noah

Noah in Genesis 6-9	Yoseph in Genesis 45
Elohim warns Noah of the coming flood: “After seven more days (לִימִים עוֹד שְׁבַע) I will bring rain upon the land” (Gen. 7:4)	“For these two years a famine (i.e., not enough water) has been in the land, and there are still five more years (וְעוֹד חֲמֵשׁ שָׁנִים) of no harvesting or reaping” (Gen. 45:6)
“You will take animals ... to keep alive (לְחַיֹּת) seed on the land on the face of the land ... (Gen 7:3) ” + “Elohim wiped away every living thing from the face of the land, but Noah and those with him were a remnant (שֹׁאֵר) in the ark” (Gen. 7:23)	“Elohim sent me before you, to set up for you a remnant (שְׁאֵרִית) in the land, and to keep alive (לְחַיֹּת) a great escaped-remnant (פְּלִיטָה)” (Gen. 45:7)
Elohim instructs Noah about how to provide food for himself, his family (“you, your sons, your wife, and your sons wives ... and all the animals”), and the animals during the flood (Gen. 6:21)	Yoseph instructs his brothers to get their father, so that he can provide them with food (“for you, your sons, and your sons’ sons, and your flocks and your cattle, and I will sustain you there”) during the famine (Gen. 45:10)
<i>The Flood Narrative in the Joseph Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Yoseph’s speech to his brothers shows how he is being portrayed as a new Noah, a righteous one that Elohim has chosen for preserving a remnant in the land, so that a new creation (human and animal!) can be birthed in a time of cosmic re-creation (the famine // the flood).

Notice the focus on the preservation of both human and animal life in both stories.

Also notice that this whole scene takes place in the Pharaoh’s “house” (הַבַּיִת), which is the word “ark” spelled backward (תֵּבָה)!

Yoseph Sends His Brother Back to Yaaqov

¹⁴ And he fell upon the neck of **Binyamin his brother** and he wept, and **Binyamin** **wept** upon his neck.

¹⁵ And he kissed all of **his brothers**, and he **wept** over them, and afterward **his brothers** spoke with him.

¹⁶ And the voice was heard in the house of Phar'oh, saying, “The **brothers of Yoseph** have come!” And it was **good in the eyes** of Phar'oh,

and **in the eyes** of his servants,

¹⁷ and Phar'oh said to Yoseph,

"Say to **your brothers**,

Do this:

a Load your beasts,

and leave, go to the land of Cana'an,

b ¹⁸ and **take** **your father** and your households,

and **come** to me,

c and **I will give** you **the good** of the land of Egypt,

and eat the fat of the land!

¹⁹ And you are being commanded.

Do this:

a' **Take** for yourselves from the land of Egypt **carts**,

for your children and for your wives,

b' and you will carry **your father**,

and you will **come**.

c' ²⁰ And **your eyes**, don't let them pity your belongings,

because **the good** of all the land of Egypt, it is for you!"

²¹ And the sons of Yisra'el did so.

And Yoseph **gave** them **carts** according to the mouth of Phar'oh,

and he **gave** them fodder **for the road**.

²² And to all of them he **gave** to each a change of clothes,

and to **Binyamin** he **gave** three hundred silver and five changes of clothes,

²³ and to **his father** he sent like this:

Ten donkeys carrying from **the good** of the land of Egypt,

and ten female donkeys carrying grain,

and bread and provisions for his father **for the road**.

²⁴ And he sent **his brothers** and they went,

and he said to them,

"Don't let yourselves get angry **on the road**."

^{25a} And so they went up out of Egypt.

Genesis 45:14-25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Brothers Dwelling Together in Unity

Yoseph's reconciliation with his brothers is portrayed with language that deliberately recalls the reconciliation of his father Yaaqov with his estranged brother Esau.

Yoseph and His Brothers: Genesis 45:14-15

And **he fell upon the neck** of Binyamin his brother
and he wept ,
and Binyamin **wept upon his neck** ,
and he **kissed** all of his brothers,
and he wept over them.

Yaaqov and Esau: Genesis 33:3-4

... and he came near to his brother.
Then Esau ran to meet him,
and he embraced him,
and **he fell on his neck** and **kissed** him,
and they wept .

Jacob and Esau Reflected in Joseph and His Brothers. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

After Yaaqov's 20-year exile, caused by his deception of his father and brother, the brothers finally meet. Yaaqov discovers mercy, and there is a powerful embrace that brings the two brothers together.

Similarly, after Yoseph's 13-year exile, caused by his brothers' jealousy and after the deception of their father, the brothers finally meet and Yoseph shows them mercy.

However, Yoseph's reconciliation with his brothers isn't just a parallel with the Yaaqov and Esau story. Both stories of reconciled siblings bring to a climax the "conflict of seeds" and "sibling rivalry" themes in the book of Genesis.

- Round 1: Humanity vs. the snake
- Round 2: Abel vs. Cain
- Round 3: Shem and Japheth vs. Ham
- Round 4: Abraham vs. Lot
- Round 5: Isaac vs. Ishmael
- Round 6: Yaaqov vs. Esau
- Round 7: Yoseph vs. his brothers

"Each of these sibling rivalries or 'seed conflicts' develops the paradigmatic conflict first announced in Genesis 3:15 and then portrayed in Cain's murder of Abel. While only Genesis 4 ends in murder, the threat of fratricide against the covenant seed looms throughout each of these conflicts. The seed conflict between Joseph and his brothers is, thus, climactic in Genesis, as the brothers' intense animosity for Joseph evokes ... Genesis 4. ... The dramatic twist in the Joseph story is that Joseph's wise plan to 'test' his brothers (42:15-16), coupled with Judah's repentance (44:18-34), lead to a reversal of the Cain and Abel story. ... The unresolved brotherly strife of previous generations is finally overcome by Yoseph's ruse in chapters 42-45, and by his refusal to exact vengeance on his brothers after Jacob's death (50:15-21). In this way, the Joseph story reverses one of the primary literary motifs in Genesis. Sibling conflict has racked the covenant family and endangered the seed since Adam and Eve's first children. Joseph undoes the cycle of violence, but only by exercising forgiveness after his own humiliation and exaltation. In this way, Joseph is an anti-Cain. He is truly his brothers' keeper."

Emadi, Samuel (2018). "Covenant Typology, and the Story of Joseph". Tyndale Bulletin. 100-101.

The Ark-Eden of Egypt

Recall how the above paragraph of Yoseph's speech (Gen. 45:4-13) portrayed him as a new Noah-like remnant who was chosen out of the generation of the famine to preserve life for a remnant that would survive through the de-creation. Here in this paragraph, that analogy continues.

Pharaoh begins commanding Yoseph and the brothers to "go" (בוא) back to their land and to "take" (לקח) their father and animals and "come into" (בוא אל) Egypt, where they can have food (אכל) and enjoy the good of the land. All of this language is a hyperlink back to God's speech to Noah before the flood.

Pharaoh to Yoseph and the Brothers: Genesis 45

17 ... "Say to your brothers,
'Do this:
Load your **animals** ,
and leave, **go to** (בוא אל) the land of
Canaan,
18 and **take** (לקח) your father and your
households,
and **come to** (בוא אל) me,
and I will give you the good of the
land of Egypt,
and **eat** (אכל) the fat of the land!
19 And you are being **commanded**
(צוה).
Do this:
Take (לקח) carts from the land of
Egypt,
for your children and for your wives,
and you will carry your father,
and you will **come** (בוא).
20 And don't let your eyes pity your
belongings,
because the good of all the land of
Egypt,
it is for you!"
21 And the sons of Yisrael **did so**
(עשה בן).

God to Noah: Genesis 6-7

Gen. 6:20 "Of the birds after their kind, and of the animals
after their kind, of every creeping thing of the ground after its
kind, two of every kind will **come to** (בוא אל) you to keep
them alive."

Gen. 7:1 Then the Lord said to Noah, "**Enter** (אל ... בוא) the
ark, you and all your household, for you alone I have seen to
be righteous before me in this time."

Gen. 6:21-22 "As for you, **take** (לקח) for yourself some of all
food that can be eaten (אכל), and gather it to yourself; and it
shall be for **food** (אכלה) for you and for them."

Gen. 7:2 "You will **take** (לקח) with you of every clean **animal**
by sevens, a male and his female; and of the **animals** that
are not clean two, a male and his female."

Gen. 6:22 **And so Noah did** (עשה); according to all that God
had **commanded** (צוה) him, **so he did** (כן עשה).

Gen. 7:5 Noah **did** (עשה) according to all that the Lord had
commanded (צוה) him.

Pharaoh Speaking to Joseph Like God Speaking to Noah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject
Classroom: Joseph (2022).

These verbal hyperlinks set up a network of analogies between the story of Noah and the flood and the story of Yoseph and the famine.

- Pharaoh // Elohim give commands to Yoseph and his brothers // Noah and his family.

- A de-creation event comes upon the land, taking away life.
- God chooses one righteous leader (Yoseph // Noah) to create a place of refuge (the “good” of Egypt // the ark) where their family can be delivered.
- The chosen ones take many animals into the refuge where they can live. Notice that the word “carts” (עגלות) is literally the Hebrew word “calves” (עגל), referring to a cart drawn by oxen.
- The chosen ones obey the commands.

Reflection Question

What are some of the ways that the biblical authors link the rescue of Yaaqov’s family in Egypt to the rescue of Noah’s family in the ark?